Towards a unified analysis of participles and nominalizations in Nor-Nakhichevan Armenian[1]

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1. Introduction

There is a typologically frequent polysemy between participial affixes and nominalization affixes. It has been mainly attested in Altaic, Uralic, Quechua and Tibeto-Burman languages (Koptjevskaya-Tamm 1993; Noonan 1997, Serdobolskaya & Paperno 2006, Shagal 2018). In this study, we expand the existing typology by adding data from Nor-Nakhichevan (Don) Armenian, an understudied Indo-European language belonging to the Western Armenian dialect group. This dialect is particularly interesting because it shows four different nominalization strategies, whereas most Armenian dialects and both literary standards have only one (the infinitive). Nominalization affixes in Nor-Nakhichevan turn out to be identical to participial suffixes. We present a formal analysis inspired by Dékány & Georgieva (2020) that accounts for these empirical data.

2. Dékány & Georgieva's (2020) account

In their study, Dékány & Georgieva discuss the polysemy between the participial affix *-m* and the gerund affix *-m-* in Udmurt. Their key argument is that the identical surface realization of these suffixes is not accidental: they are lexically the same. They further argue that this affix is located in the extended verbal projection, namely in PtcpP. Thus, they conclude that a relative clause is a bare PtcpP (1), while a gerund is a mixed projection, with PtcpP being dominated by DP (2).

(1) [NP [PtcpP [Ptcp vP m]] N]

(2) [DP [D [PtcpP [Ptcp vP m]]]]

3. Nor-Nakhichevan Armenian data

3.1. Participial relative clauses

Nor-Nakhichevan Armenian has a tripartite system of participles: an active participle (*-oʁ*), a resultative participle (*-adz*) and a future participle (*-elu*/*alu*). While *-oʁ* is specialized for subject relativization, *-adz* and *-u* can be used for relativizing almost all syntactic positions on the Keenan-Comrie Accessibility Hierarchy, including subject, direct object, indirect object, oblique, and genitive possessor.

A participial relative clause built with these participles is placed in prenominal position (3). The subject is marked with the genitive or nominative case if it is inanimate. Agreement is established between the genitive subject and the head noun. If a possessor NP is present, agreement holds between the possessor and the head (4).

(3)	axpor-əs	[**imis**	heru	kən-adz	tsi-i-**s**]
	brother-1POSS	**1SG.GEN**	last.year	buy-PTCP.RES	horse-OBJ-**1POSS**
	dzax-its^{h}.				
	sell-AOR.3SG				

‘My brother sold the horse that I bought last year.’

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(4) bedros-ə [luseʁen-i-n jantsʰətsʰ-adz **imis**
B.-DEF L.-OBJ-DEF know-PTCP.RES **1SG.GEN**
oštax-i-**s**] des-av.
friend-OBJ-**1POSS** see-AOR.3SG
'Bedros met my friend whom Lusegen knows.'

3.2. Nominalizations

Just as in Udmurt, in Nor-Nakhichevan Armenian all of the participle affixes also serve as nominalization affixes. Thus, *-oʁ* forms agent nominalizations, *-adz* forms event nominalizations with past/non-future time reference, and *-elu* forms event nominalizations with future time reference.

In nominalizations, the subject is marked with genitive or nominative case, just as in relative clauses, and agreement is established between the genitive subject and the nominalized verb (5).

(5) aram-ə **imis** ereg mašin kən-adz-**əs**
A.-DEF **1SG.GEN** yesterday car buy-PTCP.RES-**1POSS**
kid-e.
know-PRS.3SG
'Aram knows that I bought a car yesterday.'

Nominalizations demonstrate rich verbal properties: they express voice, aspect, tense, modality, and negation; they combine with adverbs and adverbial phrases; they preserve argument structure and case marking. At the same time, they exhibit only limited nominal properties: they can be arguments and adjuncts, combine with demonstratives and quantifiers, but do not allow modification by adjectives and numerals, and have only restricted number marking. This combination of verbal and nominal characteristics suggests that they are event nominalizations with a high degree of clausal preservation.

4. Analysis

We adopt Dékány & Georgieva's (2020) account and argue that Nor-Nakhichevan participial affixes and nominalization affixes are exponents of the same functional head. Following nanosyntactic assumptions (Caha 2009; Starke 2009), we propose that the lexical representation of *-adz* and *-u* contains the syntactic projection ModP (which includes at least TP and ModP). Thus, the clause is built as usual up to T; after the head T is merged, the entire functional structure is spelled out as *-adz* or *-u*. When this structure is further embedded under Mod, the functional structure is spelled out again using the same participial affixes.

5. Conclusion

We have shown that Nor-Nakhichevan Armenian exhibits the same polysemy between participial and nominalizing affixes observed in other language families. Adopting the framework of Dékány & Georgieva (2020) and incorporating nanosyntactic assumptions, we have argued for a unified syntactic analysis in which a single functional projection is responsible for both constructions. This study contributes to the typology of participial-nominalization polysemy by adding data from an Indo-European language and provides a formal account within the nanosyntactic framework.

Literature

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